

How the Bible Is Organized

Pentateuch • History • Wisdom & Poetry • Prophets • Gospels • Epistles • Revelation

This guide follows the common 66-book Protestant arrangement used in most modern Protestant Bibles, including the standard KJV book order. The Bible is a library, so these divisions describe literary and canonical groupings rather than one continuous genre.

At a Glance

Testament	Division	Books
OLD TESTAMENT	Pentateuch / Law	5
	Historical Books	12
	Wisdom & Poetry	5
	Major Prophets	5
	Minor Prophets	12
NEW TESTAMENT	Gospels	4
	History (Acts)	1
	Pauline Epistles	13
	General Epistles	8
	Apocalyptic / Prophecy (Revelation)	1

Total: 39 Old Testament books + 27 New Testament books = 66 books.

The Old Testament - 39 Books

The Old Testament traces creation, covenant, Israel's national history, worship and wisdom, prophetic warning, judgment, hope, and expectation.

1. Pentateuch / Torah / Law (5 books)

Foundation: creation, the patriarchs, the Exodus, covenant, law, wilderness, and preparation to enter the land.

Genesis	Exodus	Leviticus
Numbers	Deuteronomy	

2. Historical Books (12 books)

Israel's story in the land: conquest, judges, monarchy, divided kingdom, exile, return, and restoration.

Joshua	Judges	Ruth
1 Samuel	2 Samuel	1 Kings
2 Kings	1 Chronicles	2 Chronicles
Ezra	Nehemiah	Esther

3. Wisdom & Poetry (5 books)

Worship, suffering, wisdom, the meaning of life, righteous living, and love expressed through poetic and reflective forms.

Job	Psalms	Proverbs
Ecclesiastes	Song of Solomon (Song of Songs)	

4. Major Prophets (5 books)

Prophetic preaching and visions concerning sin, judgment, covenant faithfulness, restoration, and future hope.

Isaiah	Jeremiah	Lamentations
Ezekiel	Daniel	

5. Minor Prophets (12 books)

Shorter prophetic books addressing Israel and Judah, surrounding nations, judgment, repentance, restoration, and the Day of the LORD.

Hosea	Joel	Amos
Obadiah	Jonah	Micah
Nahum	Habakkuk	Zephaniah
Haggai	Zechariah	Malachi

The New Testament - 27 Books

The New Testament centers on Jesus Christ, the birth and growth of the church, apostolic teaching, Christian discipleship, and the final hope of God's victory and new creation.

1. The Gospels (4 books)

Four witnesses to the life, ministry, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Matthew	Mark	Luke
John		

2. History (1 book)

The continuing work of the risen Christ through the Holy Spirit as the gospel spreads from Jerusalem outward.

Acts

3. Pauline Epistles (13 books)

Letters associated with the apostle Paul, written to churches and individuals to teach doctrine, correct problems, encourage faithfulness, and shape Christian life.

Romans	1 Corinthians	2 Corinthians
Galatians	Ephesians	Philippians
Colossians	1 Thessalonians	2 Thessalonians
1 Timothy	2 Timothy	Titus
Philemon		

4. General (Catholic) Epistles (8 books)

Letters addressed more broadly to Jewish and Gentile Christians or to the church at large. Hebrews is commonly placed here in Protestant organizational charts because its author is not named.

Hebrews	James	1 Peter
2 Peter	1 John	2 John
3 John	Jude	

5. Apocalyptic / Prophecy (1 book)

A symbolic and prophetic vision of Christ's triumph, judgment, perseverance, worship, and the renewal of creation.

Revelation

One-Page Book Map

Testament	Division	Books
OLD TESTAMENT	Pentateuch	Genesis • Exodus • Leviticus • Numbers • Deuteronomy
	History	Joshua • Judges • Ruth • 1-2 Samuel • 1-2 Kings • 1-2 Chronicles • Ezra • Nehemiah • Esther
	Wisdom & Poetry	Job • Psalms • Proverbs • Ecclesiastes • Song of Solomon
	Major Prophets	Isaiah • Jeremiah • Lamentations • Ezekiel • Daniel
	Minor Prophets	Hosea • Joel • Amos • Obadiah • Jonah • Micah • Nahum • Habakkuk • Zephaniah • Haggai • Zechariah • Malachi
NEW TESTAMENT	Gospels	Matthew • Mark • Luke • John
	History	Acts
	Pauline Epistles	Romans • 1-2 Corinthians • Galatians • Ephesians • Philippians • Colossians • 1-2 Thessalonians • 1-2 Timothy • Titus • Philemon
	General Epistles	Hebrews • James • 1-2 Peter • 1-3 John • Jude
	Apocalyptic / Prophecy	Revelation

A Few Important Notes

- **These are organizational categories, not inspired chapter headings.** The biblical books themselves are Scripture; labels such as “Historical Books,” “Wisdom Literature,” and “Major Prophets” are later tools that help readers navigate the collection.
- **“Major” and “Minor” do not mean more or less important.** Those labels refer mainly to the relative length of the prophetic books, not to their authority, value, or spiritual importance.
- **The Hebrew Bible uses a different arrangement.** Jewish tradition commonly groups the Scriptures as Torah (Law), Nevi'im (Prophets), and Ketuvim (Writings) - the Tanakh. The contents overlap substantially with the Protestant Old Testament, but the ordering and book-counting conventions differ.
- **Christian canons are not identical.** Catholic and Orthodox Bibles contain additional Old Testament books or sections often called Deuterocanonical books (or Apocrypha in many Protestant contexts), and their ordering can differ.
- **Genre can overlap.** A book may fit more than one literary description. For example, Daniel contains narrative and apocalyptic material; Psalms includes wisdom psalms as well as hymns, laments, and royal psalms; Acts is history written with theological purpose.

Study tip: learn the divisions first, then learn the books inside each division. Once the structure is familiar, finding a book and understanding its broad setting becomes much easier.